Pegula Saves Match Point to Reach WTA Finals Last Four

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Jessica Pegula saved a match point and fought into the last four of the WTA Finals, beating Linda Noskova 7-6, 4-6, 7-5 in a match that swung back and forth.

Pegula had to win: Coco Gauff had beaten Marta Kostyuk earlier on Thursday, so only a win over Noskova would carry her through.

Noskova went a **break** up in the third set and held a match point on Pegula's serve at 5-4, but she could not take it. Pegula held on and closed out the match, showing great **mental resilience**.

Pegula's serve was the star of the show. She hit 16 **aces**, the most she has ever produced in a WTA Tour match, and her returns kept **wrong-footing** Noskova. Noskova struggled on her own serve, hitting 15 **double faults** against nine **aces**.

"I've learned that sometimes the serve feels good and sometimes it doesn't, and how to manage the days when it doesn't and to ride it when you are serving well," Pegula said. "Sometimes there's no rhyme or reason."

Noskova had already secured her semi-final place, where she will face either Elina Svitolina or Aryna Sabalenka on Saturday. Pegula will meet French Open champion Mirra Andreeva next. "It's the match people wanted, well now you are going to get it," Pegula said.

Earlier, Gauff had shown her own fighting spirit to beat Kostyuk. The 22-year-old, the 2024 WTA Finals champion, had treatment on her lower back midway through the match and soon found herself 5-1 down in the second set, but fought back to win. "Physically, I wasn't at my best," Gauff said. "It was like a mental challenge, learning how to play through that." It was the second time Gauff had overturned a 5-1 deficit at this tournament, after doing the same to Pegula on Sunday.

Word Treasure

aces -- In tennis, a serve that the other player cannot touch.

break -- In tennis, when a player wins a point on the other player's serve.

mental resilience -- Strength of mind; staying calm and focused under pressure.

double faults -- In tennis, a serve that goes wrong twice in a row, giving the point away.

wrong-footing -- In tennis, to hit the ball so the other player moves the wrong way.

Background you need

Tennis is a sport where two players hit a ball over a net with rackets, trying to win points, games, and sets.

The WTA Finals is a big tennis event at the end of the season, where the best women players of the year compete.

A match point is a point that would win the whole match, so saving one means staying alive when defeat is one point away.

An ace is a serve so good that the other player cannot even touch the ball.

Break it down

LEAD: Jessica Pegula saved a match point to reach the last four of the WTA Finals.
KEY EVENT: Pegula beat Linda Noskova 7-6, 4-6, 7-5.
+- WHO: Jessica Pegula and Linda Noskova
+- WHEN: Thursday, after Coco Gauff beat Marta Kostyuk
+- WHY: Only a win would carry Pegula through to the semi-finals
EVIDENCE: Pegula hit 16 aces, her most ever; Noskova hit 15 double faults.
OPEN QUESTION: Can Pegula beat Mirra Andreeva, whom she has never faced before?

Why it matters

Saving a match point and winning anyway is one of the most exciting things in sport, and it shows what mental strength can do. For young players, Pegula's win is a lesson in never giving up.

Test what you remember

1. Who saved a match point to reach the last four?

- (A) Coco Gauff
- (B) Linda Noskova
- (C) Mirra Andreeva
- (D) Jessica Pegula

2. What was the score of the Pegula-Noskova match?

- (A) 7-6, 4-6, 7-5
- (B) 7-5, 7-5
- (C) 6-3, 6-1
- (D) 6-0, 6-0

3. How many aces did Pegula serve?

- (A) 15
- (B) 6
- (C) 16
- (D) 9

4. How many double faults did Noskova hit?

- (A) 15
- (B) 9
- (C) 16
- (D) 5

5. Who will Pegula face in the semi-finals?

- (A) Elina Svitolina
- (B) Mirra Andreeva
- (C) Aryna Sabalenka
- (D) Marta Kostyuk

6. How far down was Gauff in the second set before she fought back against Kostyuk?

- (A) 5-1
- (B) 3-1
- (C) 6-1
- (D) 4-1

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Jessica Pegula: She said she has learned to manage the days when her serve feels good and the days when it does not.**

2. **Coco Gauff: She said she was not at her best physically, and that playing through it was a mental challenge.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):